STATUS REPORT

Uganda — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-08-31 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

NITA-U's five-year digital strategy, launched in June 2026, redefines success as citizen utilisation rather than infrastructure count, commits to a Client Charter and quarterly public reporting, and records public satisfaction with e-services at 22.2% against a target of 35%. Active use of e-government services sits well below the strategy's own target.

The governing stack behind that is old. The National ICT Policy 2014 remains the sector policy, spanning connectivity, cybersecurity, broadcasting, e-government, e-commerce, payments and skills. The National E-Government Policy Framework dates from 2011 and the Electronic Waste Management Policy from 2012; the National Broadband Policy 2018 sets the connectivity framework. The cross-cutting instrument is the Digital Transformation Roadmap of August 2023, covering broadband, data centres, cybersecurity, data protection, payments, startups and skills, with the Digital Government Strategy providing a five-year implementation plan under the twenty-year Digital Uganda Vision. Financial inclusion runs on the National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2023–2028, which widens its priority groups to refugees and persons with disabilities. The National Social Protection Strategy of February 2025 still describes strengthening the social registry and operationalising the National Single Registry as forward priorities rather than completed work. The newest addition is the updated National Information Security Framework launched in July 2026, setting minimum security controls across institutions, delivered under the donor-financed Uganda Digital Acceleration Project.

On who owns delivery, the World Bank's 2025 index records Uganda as having a current digital transformation strategy with coordination machinery that is institutionalised rather than ad hoc, an established institution with a GovTech mandate and an autonomous data governance body whose approach it classes as holistic. Artificial intelligence has a home in the ministry: a standing AI Secretariat headed by Ambrose Ruyooka is tasked with laying the groundwork across agriculture, health diagnostics, education and public administration, though the strategy itself was still at the stakeholder-engagement stage in March 2026 and no AI instrument has been adopted to sit behind it.

Legislation and regulation

In March 2026 Uganda's Constitutional Court struck down Sections 11, 23, 26, 27, 28 and 29 of the Computer Misuse Act — the provisions criminalising unauthorised access and recording, "offensive", "malicious" and "unsolicited" information, and social-media misuse — and voided Sections 162 and 163 of the Penal Code, the criminal libel provisions. The Court nullified them on two grounds: that Parliament lacked quorum when they were passed, and that they were "overly broad, vague and ambiguous". They had been the state's principal instruments for prosecuting online speech, and no equivalent statutory basis now stands in their place.

The rest of the statute book is older and intact. The Computer Misuse Act No. 2 of 2011 remains the principal cybercrime statute; the Uganda Communications Act 2013 reaches broadband, broadcasting, data centres, digital identification, payments and e-commerce; the Electronic Signature Act 2011 gives electronic signatures legal standing; the Registration of Persons Act 2015 is the identity statute; and the National Payment Systems Act 2020 makes the Bank of Uganda both operator and supervisor of the core rails.

The largest hole is in what authorises the executive to switch the network off. The Uganda Communications Commission directed the CEOs of all licensed operators and internet service providers to suspend public internet services from 18:00 on 13 January 2026. The Uganda Law Society's position is that section 87 of the UCC Act permits suspension only under a state of emergency declared under Article 110 of the Constitution, and none had been declared; Parliament's Public Accounts Committee (Central) ordered the government to table the directives behind the shutdown.

Subordinate law moves further than headline statute. Statutory Instrument No. 67 of 2024, gazetted on 12 August 2024, made the national identification card valid for eleven years and is deemed to have come into force on 20 November 2015 — a retroactive commencement of eight years and nine months. On virtual assets, cryptocurrency is not legal tender, a 2023 High Court ruling barred conversion between crypto and mobile money under the National Payment Systems Act 2020, and the Bank of Uganda licenses no crypto services (June 2025).

Data protection

Uganda's data-protection regulator has decided two cases against foreign controllers and fined neither. On 20 February 2026 the Personal Data Protection Office partly upheld a complaint against WhatsApp LLC and Meta Platforms, Inc., finding deficiencies in transparency, in tying processing purposes to a lawful basis, and in demonstrating cross-border transfer compliance. It issued five corrective orders on a 90-day clock: a rewritten Uganda-facing privacy policy, separation of core-messaging processing from ancillary ecosystem processing with granular opt-in for profiling, and documented adequacy, impact and legitimate-interests assessments. No fine followed, although Regulation 48 carries a daily fine and Regulation 30(6) extends to imprisonment for a natural person.

Jurisdiction over both non-resident respondents was taken under section 1(b) of Cap. 97, applying the Office's own Google ruling of 18 July 2025, which had found Google in breach for operating without registration and transferring Ugandans' data abroad. The Office cannot award compensation, section 33(1) sending claims for damages to the courts, and an appeal against its decisions lies to the Minister of ICT and National Guidance within 30 days, so the first level of review sits with the executive rather than with a court. Domestic enforcement runs at another scale: the first local prosecution under the Act, in December 2025, followed a client's data circulating among a courier's delivery agents, and a guilty plea to operating unregistered drew a fine of UGX 100,000.

The data exchange between NIRA and the Electoral Commission operates without a codified, publicly available governance framework in March 2026, and NIRA opened an investigation with the Office and the police in September 2025 after allegations that staff had sold data from the National Identification Register. Breach notification is mandatory under regulation 33 with section 23 of the Act, and the Office, not the controller, then decides whether data subjects are told.

The courts have read the existing regime as sufficient. In June 2025 the High Court held that public health services are not among those listed in section 66(2) of the Registration of Persons Act 2015, so Ugandan law imposes no requirement to use the national ID to reach them.

Regional collaboration

Inflows through the East African Payment System reached UGX 1.3 trillion in FY2024/25, up 17%, with Kenyan and Tanzanian currency accounting for 99% of activity.

The rules lag the plumbing. At its 29th Ordinary Meeting on 24 July 2026 the East African Community's Monetary Affairs Committee held the single currency target at 2031 while minuting that no partner state, Uganda included, has attained all four primary macroeconomic convergence criteria, and agreed a peer review mechanism for macroeconomic surveillance and operational frameworks for the EAC Five-Year Development Strategy 2026/27–2030/31. The same signed communique records no artificial intelligence item and no regulatory-sandbox item, despite the chair's call for a harmonised regional framework. The Community's rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection were approved only at official level on 24 July 2026 and still have to pass its decision-making organs, so Uganda is not yet bound by them and no adoption date is published.

Uganda belongs to three regional economic communities: COMESA, the East African Community and IGAD. Its national identification card is accepted as a travel document between Uganda, Kenya and Rwanda under a tripartite arrangement dating from January 2014, but not across all EAC partner states. Physical reach is extending independently of the treaty work: a 2,000 km protected fibre route from Goma to Mombasa now runs via Kigali, Kampala and Nairobi. Uganda is not among the sovereigns financed by the World Bank's Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project.

Integration itself has been going backwards. Uganda's Regional Integration score fell 17.8 points over 2014–2023 to 54.0 out of 100, 17th of 54 African states, and is among the country's ten most deteriorated indicators.

Standards

Uganda completed the renewal of its digital government frameworks on 27 May 2026, delivering a renewed Government Enterprise Architecture aligned to Uganda Vision 2040 and an enhanced e-Government Interoperability Framework for standardised data exchange across government systems. Both documents dated from 6 May 2021, had reached their five-year mark, and were renewed by NITA-U with World Bank support and Estonia's e-Governance Academy, in work launched at a multi-agency workshop in Kampala that concluded on 18 February 2026. The renewal ran from November 2025 to May 2026 and covered assessment, cross-sector consultation, updated recommendations and workshops preparing institutions for a rollout that had not begun when the work was reported complete. The architecture's stated purpose is to serve as a blueprint ensuring government systems are designed to collaborate rather than grow in isolation.

The interoperability framework is issued as a mandatory technical standard binding all ministries, departments, agencies and local governments, modelled on the European Interoperability Framework. Adoption is another matter: the World Bank's 2025 index records the framework and the government service bus that carries it as only partially used across government.

Elsewhere the country builds to external standards one system at a time rather than by general rule. Registration kits fitted for the 2024–2026 enrolment campaign hold MOSIP L0 compliance and were among the first certified under MOSIP's MACP framework; a domestic cybersecurity firm took ISO/IEC 27001 certification in January 2026, making the standard attainable without a foreign provider; and the updated National Information Security

Framework of July 2026 sets minimum security controls and provisions for protecting critical information infrastructure. The electronic government procurement platform is being onboarded in phases each financial year until the whole of government is covered.

One general rule is absent: Uganda has no government open source software policy, and the sub-questions that would describe one are recorded as not applicable.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Uganda's Digital Freedom score stands at 22.9 out of 100 (2023), 47th of 54 African states and down 11.6 points over the decade, among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators. The wider Rights sub-category sits at 39.9 out of 100 (2023), with Media Freedom at 41.9 and Personal Liberties at 22.0, all three down over the decade.

The law moved the other way in March 2026, when the Constitutional Court nullified the Computer Misuse Act's online-speech provisions and voided the Penal Code's criminal libel sections, removing the state's principal statutory basis for prosecuting speech online. Platform-level control has not followed the law. Facebook has remained officially restricted since the 2021 election blackout, with the use of VPNs to circumvent the block declared illegal. Around the January 2026 election, general public internet access was restored on 18 January while social media and messaging applications remained restricted, and the restrictions were only lifted in full by public notice of 26 January 2026. Six weeks before that election the Electoral Commission had met the international platforms, called them "unruly" and "ungovernable" and asked them to "whip their users" — a request they declined.

Government's expectation of the press is explicit. The ICT minister told the Editors Guild in August 2026 that journalists should "focus on constructive reporting that contributes to national development", and a day earlier commended the media for promoting government programmes. The sector's own headline account of itself is the regulator's: the State of the Digital Economy conference of 29 July 2026 is convened and presented by the Uganda Communications Commission.

On access to records the position is formally strong and practically bounded. The Access to Information Act 2005 establishes the right to request state-held records, and the World Bank's 2025 index assesses the right-to-information law as effective rather than merely enacted, alongside an online citizen participation platform in use. Against that, the PPDA Appeals Tribunal has held that an evaluation report in a live procurement is confidential under section 106(4) of the PPDA Act, entitling a rejected bidder only to the reasons for rejection and the stage at which it occurred.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The largest thing Uganda has signed for digital work is a plan rather than a commitment. The United States has set out about US$113 million for health data systems over 2026 to 2030 under the America First Global Health Strategy memorandum of understanding, starting at US$26.1 million in 2026 and falling to US$9.8 million in 2030, with the money at pipeline stage and nothing yet disbursing. The data-systems line is one component of a wider health package planning roughly US$1.7 billion of American support against roughly US$577 million from Uganda, both sides' figures being planned rather than appropriated.

The other agreements on the record are smaller. A Uganda–UK memorandum with the civil-society body Spotlight on Africa provides for a UGX 3bn ICT hub in Mbale to prepare young women for ICT and entrepreneurship careers (February 2026). The Ministry of ICT signed a memorandum in April 2026 with the UN Health Industry Foundation and the Prince Kimbugwe Foundation covering AI labs, youth skills training and exchange programmes with China on smart agriculture. Centenary Group, through Centenary Technology Services, has signed a memorandum with MicroPay Uganda to develop school-fees saving and instalment payment platforms, lending against payment history, agent-network delivery of healthcare payments and digitised insurance claims (July 2026). Each of these sets out what the parties mean to do, and none of them attaches a disbursement or a date by which it must be done.

New investments

Twenty external financing commitments to Uganda's digital estate are on the record (August 2026), together worth about US$1.01 billion, placed between 2015 and 2026 and running to 2030. Thirteen are active, four have closed, one is at pipeline stage and one was approved but never confirmed running; seven have end dates beyond 2026. Concessional lending dominates, at about US$452 million across five loans, against US$280 million in seven grants, US$77 million in three equity deals, US$28 million in two commercial loans, one US$59 million guarantee and one small technical assistance package. The World Bank is the largest financier at about US$288 million across three operations, ahead of the Mastercard Foundation at US$200 million, China Eximbank at about US$164 million and the U.S. Department of State at US$113 million.

The largest single commitment is the World Bank's Uganda Digital Acceleration Project, or GovNet, running 2021 to 2027 behind a national government network, digital public services, broadband and inclusion. China Eximbank is financing Phase V of the national data transmission backbone on twenty-year concessional terms, repeating the 2015 Phase 3 loan that put a turnkey Huawei contract behind it; European development finance is behind 506 solar-powered rural towers; and MIGA's guarantee covers the TPG Rise Fund's equity in Airtel's Ugandan mobile money business rather than money into the system.

Private risk capital is thin and thinning: startup investment fell about 60% to US$10.6 million in 2023, from US$26.8 million in 2022. Two announcements sit outside the committed record — Global Settlement Network's plan with Uganda's Diacente Group to build digital infrastructure and pilot a bond-backed central bank digital currency anchored on Karamoja, and Global Settlement Holdings' April 2026 move to take a majority stake in Akiba International and run a tokenised-asset exchange in the regulatory sandboxes. Neither carries committed money.

Neither digital identity nor cybersecurity appears as a financed line of its own: the updated National Information Security Framework came as an output of the digital acceleration project, and the identity system has leaned on World Bank lending and UNICEF support against a domestic funding shortfall.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Uganda's telecoms regulator counted 13.3 million unique mobile subscribers against 45 million registered subscriptions (2023), so the 76 to 83% penetration usually quoted counts SIM cards, not people; the share holding a connection of their own is nearer a quarter to a third.

On the World Bank's measure around 15.3% of Ugandans used the internet (2023), against 4G coverage reaching about 96% of the population (2023). What is scarce is not signal but terms: a study the regulator commissioned itself found Uganda's telecom taxes among the most burdensome in East Africa (June 2026), and it counts only about 20 million smartphones (July 2026).

The Commission ordered a national internet blackout on 13 January 2026, two days before the presidential election, leaving online only a whitelist of hospitals, payment infrastructure and the Electoral Commission's portals, with mobile VPNs disabled. Independent measurement put the loss at four days and five hours, Uganda's total at five shutdowns and 5,188 hours since 2019.

The blackout was the measured part of a longer restriction. The Commission announced the restoration of general public internet access — browsing, news, government portals and financial services — on 18 January 2026, and only by public notice of 26 January were services restored without the previously imposed restrictions.

China Eximbank is financing Phase V of the national data transmission backbone with a concessional loan of CNY 1,049,999,568, about US$147 million, on 20-year terms at 2% interest, implemented by NITA-U with CITCC as contractor (2024), continuing a backbone built almost entirely on Chinese lending. Phase V is to lay 3,604 km of fibre with 2,240 km of last mile to 800 government sites, with the new Service Uganda Centres' throughput made contingent on it (July 2026).

Commercial routes are lit faster: Paratus' 2,000 km protected route from Goma to Mombasa via Kampala (February 2026), and Savanna Fibre has put gigabit fixed broadband on the retail market (May 2026). The Uganda Internet Exchange Point, meanwhile, began and ended 2024 with 32 connected networks and around 40 Gbps of peak traffic.

Connectivity takes more than half the money committed to Uganda's digital estate (August 2026): about US$530 million across seven commitments.

Data Storage

Uganda's sovereign cloud is sovereign at the service layer only: ABQ Cloud's ecosystem, launched in March 2026, runs inside Raxio's data centre at Namanve, so the operator is Ugandan and the building is not.

The state keeps its own estate at home. NITA-U operates a national data centre alongside an adopted government cloud strategy, and the country runs a single shared private government cloud offering infrastructure as a service to public bodies (2025) under a residency condition, though general law imposes no data localisation requirement (2024). NITA-U's five-year strategy puts the national data centre's utilisation at around 70% (June 2026).

Commercially the market is shallow. Raxio runs a Tier III colocation facility outside Kampala, Liquid launched the first Microsoft Azure Stack physically located in Uganda in August 2024, MTN says it runs six data centres in the country (August 2024), and one of the continent's largest colocation operators, Africa Data Centres, had no Ugandan facility (August 2024). Centenary Group's Green Tier 3 build at Masaka, intended to host critical government systems, was reported in August 2025 as on schedule for late 2025 and then rescheduled to launch in the first quarter of 2026.

The most-announced facility does not exist. Synectics and Schneider Electric plan USIO, a 10MW sovereign supercomputer on NVIDIA Blackwell hardware at the Karuma hydropower plant, and as at September 2025 the site was planned and under development with no built capacity. Compute that does exist arrived through the universities: a national AI research cloud launched at Makerere with RENU in March 2026, whose stated purpose is to replace foreign cloud services on data-sovereignty grounds.

Uganda's compute estate is a pipeline rather than an inventory: of the data centre and cloud projects on the record, most are announcements, plans or ecosystem launches rather than operating facilities built for the purpose.

Energy

Uganda's access to energy scores 21.7 out of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index (2023), 41st of 54 African states and among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators even after gaining 12.8 points over the decade — against an infrastructure sub-category of 39.9 that is one of only six moving with the grain of improvement. About 51.5% of the population had electricity (2023), with rural access trailing urban by a wide margin, and generation dominated by hydropower (2021).

The digital build routes around the grid where it can. The 506 rural towers TowerCo of Africa Uganda is building are powered primarily by renewable energy, at least half of them in areas with no mobile service at all (2023), financed by a US$40 million syndication in which Belgium's BIO, the European Investment Bank and Austria's OeEB each hold a share (2024).

Where it cannot, the grid sets the pace. NIRA gave heavy rainfall causing power and connectivity outages, alongside ageing equipment, as the reason its 2024 registration drive had not started (October 2024). The country's largest announced compute project takes the opposite approach and sites itself at the generator: the Karuma design case rests on surplus pre-transmission power from the 600MW plant, with the machines cooled by Nile water.

Technical Capacity

The identity authority was running at 70% of its approved workforce in August 2026, up from 48% in December 2023, with 25 districts served by a single member of staff. The Auditor General's December 2023 report found 410 of NIRA's 856 approved positions filled — 446 vacancies, or 52%, and the authority told Parliament its staffing had never exceeded half the establishment, a ratio of one officer to 80,000 unregistered Ugandans (July 2024). A district staffed by one person has no separation of duties, which makes the shortfall a control question as well as a throughput one.

The gap is filled by temporary hire rather than establishment: about 156,000 people applied for 13,787 temporary registration posts across 135 districts and 11 cities (October 2024).

Beyond the registry, the institutions that build and run systems are thin and externally leaned. Core identity technology rests on an Indian system integrator building on the MOSIP and OpenCRVS platforms, with card and equipment contracts held abroad (2024). The national AI research cloud launched at Makerere with RENU in March 2026 puts locally hosted compute in academic hands for the first time. Uganda's active developer community numbers in the thousands (2025). In the financial sector a shortage of cybersecurity skills is named as the leading constraint on defence (January 2026).

Funding is as awkward as headcount. The ICT institute paid staff salaries out of internally generated revenue until the finance ministry agreed to take on part of its wage bill, and the phased arrangement has left it unable to fully absorb what it is allocated (July 2026) — this against a comparatively strong showing on the Ibrahim Index's effective administration measure.

Cybersecurity

A backlog of 887 cybercrime cases sat in the investigative and prosecution pipeline, roughly twice the number of cases recorded in a year (January 2026). Police-recorded cybercrime in 2024 carried losses of UGX 72.1bn, about US$20 million, and the financial sector — banks, insurers, fintechs and mobile-money operators — is among the most targeted, with the mobile-money last mile the point of greatest exposure.

The framework has been refreshed faster than the defence. Uganda adopted a National Cyber Security Strategy in January 2023, its principal cybercrime statute remains the Computer Misuse Act 2011, and the ICT ministry launched an updated National Information Security Framework in July 2026 setting minimum controls across institutions and provisions for critical information infrastructure. A cyber incident involving the central bank was cited by government as part of the case for it, and NITA-U put the task as moving "from awareness to implementation".

The state's own systems are where the gap shows. The World Bank's identity diagnostic recommended that NIRA commission cybersecurity audits and establish a security operations centre (2024). In September 2025 an investigation alleging that NIRA staff sold data from the national register prompted an inquiry with the data protection office and the police. Under the 2021 data protection regulations a controller must notify the Personal Data Protection Office where it believes personal data has been accessed by an unauthorised person, the Office then deciding whether data subjects are told. Bank of Uganda attributed a contraction in debit-card and internet-banking use in FY2024/25 to cyber-security fears.

Capability is also being built at the network layer. The regulator is convening broadcasters, the mobile operators, the revenue authority and the registration bureau into a national anti-piracy framework (July 2026), with network-level blocking among the enforcement mechanisms under discussion and participants flagging the need to protect legitimate services. On the supply side, the Ugandan firm Milima Security holds ISO/IEC 27001, putting the standard within reach of a domestic provider rather than only of foreign ones (January 2026).

DPI

Data Exchange

Uganda's government service bus reached 37% of ministries, departments and agencies in June 2026, with NITA-U's new five-year strategy targeting 73% by FY2029/30. Most of what crosses it is not government-to-government: of the entities onboarded to UgHub by 2024, only 47 were ministries, departments and agencies, the rest mostly private banks and fintechs. Identity is the traffic. NIRA is one of the largest data providers on the platform, its records consumed by 90 of the 135 entities onboarded (2024), and NITA-U's own account has the exchange only partly built, with the citizen portal and unified messaging live but the full public key infrastructure ecosystem still in development (2025).

The working integrations cluster around revenue and registration. The Uganda Registration Services Bureau's system is integrated with the revenue authority, NIRA and NITA-U for end-to-end business processing (2023/24); the national land information system has been extending its integration through UgHub, particularly to the revenue authority and the Judiciary (2024); and the revenue authority's Instant TIN interface joins URA, NIRA and URSB in a live three-way link (2025). Against that, URA exchanges data with NIRA and URSB largely through point-to-point links rather than through UgHub (2024), which is the pattern the exchange was built to replace.

The e-Government Interoperability Framework is a mandatory technical standard binding all ministries, departments, agencies and local governments, though local government ICT adoption lags far behind the national picture. Both that framework and the Government Enterprise Architecture beneath it date from 2021 and were renewed in a programme completed on 27 May 2026, with the rollout to institutions still to begin.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Uganda has printed far more national identity cards than it has put in citizens' hands: 10,152,559 printed and 7,261,435 shipped by 8 February 2026, against 2,581,457 collected. The enrolment drive behind those cards has run two very different courses. Renewals reached 14.3 million against a target of 15.8 million by February 2026, while first-time enrolments reached 6.4 million against a target of 17.2 million — renewal nearly done, first registration barely a third of the way. The register held 34,697,582 citizens at 31 December 2025, 75.6% of the projected eligible population, and NIRA told Parliament that most of those still unregistered are children.

The technical rebuild is genuine. NIRA completed MOSIP's first brownfield migration, moving 28.57 million legacy records off a Neurotechnology biometric system over seven months and finding roughly 200,000 duplicates (February 2026), and iris capture was added across the registration kits after NIRA found about a million people already on the register whose stored fingerprints fail matching.

Compulsion is settled law. The High Court dismissed the challenge brought by the Initiative for Social and Economic Rights and two others in June 2025, upholding mandatory use of the national ID for public services, while recording in the same ruling that the system 'cannot be categorized as a digital ID system since in majority of cases it operates offline'. The card gates the Social Assistance Grants for Empowerment, NSSF benefits and school capitation grants, and a National Identification Number has been required for SIM registration since 2017, with all five mobile operators connected to NIRA for biometric verification. Refugees and asylum seekers cannot be enrolled at all and rely on documents from the Office of the Prime Minister and UNHCR.

Civil registration is now under the same roof: births, deaths and marriages passed from the Uganda Registration Services Bureau to NIRA in April 2025, and a National Identification Number is assigned when a birth is registered. Completeness is the constraint: the Bureau of Statistics puts birth registration completeness for under-one live births at 3.4% and death registration at 3.9% (2024).

Digital Payments and Fintech

From 1 January 2027 Ugandans may withdraw no more than UGX 50 million a day and UGX 250 million a week in cash over the counter, and businesses no more than UGX 500 million a day and UGX 2.5 billion a week, under a Bank of Uganda circular of 29 May 2026 written expressly to push volume onto mobile and internet banking and RTGS. The same circular halves interbank cheque limits, from UGX 10 million to UGX 5 million and from US$2,750 to US$1,375.

The rails already carry most of the volume. Electronic money transaction value rose 28.6% to UGX 326 trillion in FY2024/25 and agent banking grew 76.1% to UGX 29.4 trillion across 22,793 agents, while the two screen-based channels went backwards: debit card use fell 5.1% to 3.6 million and internet banking users fell 6.6% to 0.9 million, which the central bank put down to cyber-security fears. Financial inclusion stood at 70% and the central bank's e-payments index at 37% in FY2024/25, and the national payment switch was still in progress in October 2025.

Mobile money is the market. MTN MoMo Uganda handles more than US$14 billion (UGX 55 trillion) a year across over 10 million active users (June 2025), shareholders approved separating the business into a standalone fintech in July 2025, and in the first half of 2026 fintech revenue of Ush580.6 billion overtook data revenue for the first time. That concentration is also the exposure: mobile money services were down for two days around the 15 January 2026 poll and were restored on 20 January.

Licensing continues to open. The cross-border remittance fintech NALA was licensed as both a payment service provider and a payment system operator in December 2025 and Payaza took a payment system operator licence in February 2026, while cryptocurrency is not legal tender and the Bank of Uganda licenses no crypto services. Paying the state is a live channel rather than a pilot: the revenue authority takes tax payments over MTN Mobile Money, including a free USSD short code available on any handset (December 2025).

Registries

Uganda's land register is nationally digital and mostly empty: the National Land Information System runs across 22 Ministry Zonal Offices with real-time replication and holds roughly 1.5 million parcels, but the World Bank estimates only around 22% of parcels are registered (2024). Around 80% of landholdings are held under customary tenure, which is where the missing coverage sits.

Business registration has moved fastest. The Online Business Registration System has been available nationwide since December 2022 and was replaced in June 2026 by a unified e-Registry covering business, intellectual property and other registrations, and URSB launched a centralised digital Non-Individual Register in May 2026 covering companies, partnerships, NGOs, cooperatives and community-based organisations, each entity on it carrying a

Unique Entity Registration Number meant as the corporate counterpart to the personal National Identification Number. Delivery has been uneven: the Auditor General's FY2025 report flags continuing performance and reliability problems with the business registration system despite an investment of UGX 6.5 billion.

The voters' register is the most tightly joined of them all. The Electoral Commission builds it by extracting verified citizen data from the NIRA database, adding newly eligible eighteen-year-olds by National Identification Number, and deployed 109,142 biometric verification kits across 50,739 polling stations for the January 2026 elections. International IDEA records 21,649,067 registered voters against an estimated voting-age population of 24,487,969 for that election.

Social protection is the weak link. The National Single Registry has been operational since February 2021 but cannot support beneficiary targeting, with a dynamic social registry module still under construction, and only the Public Service Pensions Scheme has finished adding National Identification Numbers to its beneficiary database (2025). Two registers are only now being created: NIRA began registering legally resident foreign nationals for the first time on 10 June 2026, a gap the Auditor General had repeatedly flagged, and Uganda still has no operational national address register, Posta Uganda having received UGX 280 million of the UGX 5 billion it sought for nationwide GPS-based mapping (January 2026).

Sectoral management information systems

The health system's electronic records reach almost none of the facilities most Ugandans use: the Ministry of Health's rollout had by 2025 reached five Health Centre IVs and two Health Centre IIIs nationwide, having concentrated on national, regional and general hospitals. DHIS2 runs nationally and a health information exchange exists, so aggregate reporting is digital while the patient record largely is not, and the disease-specific UgandaEMR platform reaches only selected Health Centre II antiretroviral sites, where clinics keep paper registers for routine care alongside it.

Education runs on the same split. The national Education Management Information System exists and the examinations board is digitised, but the DHIS2-based education system supports termly capture in only a small number of districts, with a 2025 initiative in Gulu extending capture from district level down to individual schools, and rural primary schools still complete Annual School Census forms on paper for later keying.

Revenue and public finance are the strongest. The taxpayer register is nationally operational across the TIN system, the e-tax portal and the EFRIS electronic fiscal receipting and invoicing system, and registered individual taxpayers reached 5.01 million in FY2024/25, more than double the level four years earlier — while around a thousand taxpayers account for 76% of revenue collected. The replacement for that platform is stuck: the PPDA Appeals Tribunal set aside URA's technical evaluation for the e-tax2 procurement on 3 October 2025 and ordered re-evaluation of all six proposals within 20 working days. Elsewhere in the centre, the financial management information system covers both central and local government and is interfaced through the government service bus, the treasury single account is recorded as used by all ministries, departments and agencies and customs runs an off-the-shelf system connected both directly and through the service bus.

Two systems sit at the extremes. The Parish Development Model Information System has digitised over 8 million household records, about 79% of households, and verifies beneficiary National Identification Numbers against NIRA; the Crime Records Management System was upgraded in 2021 but remained under testing beyond Kampala, with no confirmed extension to stations outside the metropolitan area since.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Only 9.2% of Ugandans actively use e-government services, against a NITA-U target of 40% by FY2029/30 — a striking figure for a country the World Bank's 2025 GovTech Maturity Index places in Group A, its highest band, alongside Kenya, Rwanda, Tanzania and Egypt. Part of the answer is that there is no front door: every one of the index's seven measures of a unified national service portal is recorded as absent, while sector portals for tax, social protection and public sector jobs are separately in use. A ministerial workshop in May 2026 pressed for a single unified, citizen-centred and interoperable platform to replace the fragmented systems.

What a citizen can actually do online is narrower than the count of systems suggests, and the best of it is old. The Driver Licensing System has authenticated applicants against NIRA and taken payment through the revenue authority since 2020, cutting licence issuance to under thirty minutes; UGPass provides national authentication and electronic signatures for government portals, with a national ID required to onboard; electronic filing across the courts has been mandatory under Statutory Instrument 21 of 2025, using a case management system live since 2022, though the Uganda Law Society contests the access guidelines attached to it as incompatible with open justice (July 2026).

Where the state cannot deliver a portal it is delivering a counter. Nineteen Service Uganda Centres are being rolled out as one-stop shops, of which six were operational at July 2026 — Entebbe, Kasese, Jinja, Arua, Hoima and the ministry's own headquarters — each consolidating national ID verification, tax registration, business registration, passports and driving permits under one roof. On the supply side, the electronic government procurement system now reaches 136 public entities, 36 live and 100 in training (August 2026), and the ICT ministry has called for locally built prototype government systems spanning tax, land, hospital records, employment and digital identity. The underlying constraint is visible in the UN's own numbers: Uganda's online service index stands at 0.6069 and its human capital index at 0.5023, against a telecommunication infrastructure index of 0.2299 (2024).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

ICT adoption across Uganda's districts and local governments remained under 5% in a 2024 case study drawing on the national ICT survey, so although the government interoperability framework's mandate covers local government, districts barely register as technical participants in the national data exchange.

What exists below the centre is largely the centre reaching down. The Ministry of Public Service is rolling out nineteen Service Uganda Centres as one-stop shops, of which NITA-U funds only three — Tororo, Mbarara and Gulu — as pilots under the UDAP-GovNet programme, the rest carried by the ministry itself (July 2026). The Gulu centre is a UGX 4bn build with more than forty workstations shared by the registration services bureau, the revenue authority and the identity authority, put up by the UPDF Engineering Brigade (March 2026), and Tororo's was inspected for readiness on 27 July 2026. Throughput at the centres is made contingent on the fifth phase of the national backbone, the build meant to reach the districts and sub-counties the first four phases did not.

The digital systems that do run at district level are national systems with a district endpoint rather than local ones. Birth and death notification reaches most districts through the mobile vital records system, with the digital entry itself made at district registration centres rather than at the sub-county offices where births are recorded on paper; the Parish Development Model monitoring platform shows beneficiaries, funds disbursed, utilisation and loan repayments down to village level (July 2026); and termly education data capture on the national DHIS2 platform runs in only a small number of districts.

Rural digital data capture

A rural district registration office handled 60 to 150 people a day in July 2024, against 600 to 1,000 in a Kampala office, and in the districts the identity authority did not reach at all, such as Kalaki and Kapelebyong, people travelled 80 to 100 kilometres to reach one.

Where data arises outside the capital, the default record is still paper. Rural primary schools keep attendance and administrative records on paper, head teachers completing manual Annual School Census forms that are keyed into the national education management information system afterwards; the DHIS2-based education system supports termly capture in a small number of districts, and a 2025 initiative in Gulu is extending capture from the district down to individual schools. Rural civil registry offices register births on paper forms completed at sub-county and division offices, the digital notification system sitting at hospitals and district registration centres rather than at first contact. Clinics are further behind: the electronic medical records rollout has concentrated on national, regional and general hospitals and by 2025 had reached few lower-tier health centres, while the disease-specific UgandaEMR platform at selected antiretroviral therapy sites leaves some rural clinics capturing part of patient data digitally and keeping paper for routine care. The police crime records system was first piloted in ten Kampala Metropolitan divisions from 2017; the 2025 Sub-County Policing Model deploys personnel to every sub-county.

In agriculture the register itself is still being built: farmer registries were in development in 2025 and no national digital agriculture strategy had been adopted. External money is aimed at the gap: Sweden funded UNCDF's Connect Rural Uganda with SEK 139,200,000 (about US$15 million at 2019 rates), covering rural broadband, mobile money and digital agricultural information services, and the programme has now closed on a 2019–2025 term: its close-out records more than 3.4 million registered users of whom only about 29% were active, more than 21,000 digital agents and community enablers recruited and 26 services and business models piloted, with its own materials stating that technology alone could not close the usage gap (August 2026), and no successor instrument, budget line or transfer of assets is on file, and a digital sub-component of the Climate Smart Agricultural Transformation Project finances weather stations and mobile advisory services for farmers to 2028. Land runs the other way: a 2025 administrative circular makes physical inspection of larger parcels mandatory before any subdivision or transfer is registered, and most of the country's land is held under customary tenure outside the formal register.

Technology

AI

The only artificial-intelligence capability actually running in Uganda is a research facility: the National AI Research Cloud, launched at Makerere University with the Research and Education Network for Uganda in March 2026, on the argument that Ugandan research data should not have to sit on Amazon's or Google's servers.

Government's own systems run none of it: neither the Digital Government Strategy nor the e-Government Interoperability Framework provides for any AI deployment in the national data exchange (2025). The compute that would sit under a larger programme is not built either — the AI facility announced for the Karuma hydropower plant was still a plan with no built capacity as at September 2025.

Nothing has been adopted on the policy side in over a year of announcements. A first-ever national AI policy was named a priority of the fourth National Development Plan in June 2025, intended to run across innovation, data governance, cybersecurity and ethics for the whole country rather than for government alone, with the data volumes thrown off by the national ID system and by smart agriculture given as the reason for it. The ICT ministry has a standing AI Secretariat under Ambrose Ruyooka, and the strategy was still at the stakeholder-engagement stage in March 2026; in August 2026 the ICT minister was again describing an AI policy as in development. AI governance was not among the priorities the same ministry set out at the State of the Digital Economy Conference in July 2026.

What deployment there is comes through partners rather than the state — a UK-funded programme to scale digital and AI technologies in Ugandan agriculture running to 2029, an April 2026 memorandum with the UN Health Industry Foundation covering AI labs and smart-agriculture exchanges with China, and an inclusive AI curriculum in development at the ICT institute (November 2025). Uganda's editors' guild raised the misuse of AI in newsrooms at its August 2026 meeting.

ICT Industry

Uganda's pitch to investors is hardware rather than apps: its second Investor Summit in June 2025 put manufacturing, hardware, logistics and deep science ahead of consumer startup ventures, with the science and technology ministry seeking capital to commercialise that work, and the state-backed vehicle manufacturer Kiira Motors supplied the domestically built electric bus that carried delegates to it.

What the state itself buys tells the other half of the story. The new national ID system is run for NIRA by a UAE-based provider assembling components from several foreign vendors (February 2026); card production sits with a state-owned security printing company part-held by a German consortium, established under a fifteen-year partnership covering all of the country's security documents; and the Revenue Authority's replacement tax system went through the procurement tribunal, which recorded one bidder disqualified for declining to commit to transferring ownership of the source code, base framework and documentation to URA (October 2025). Parliament has twice been drawn into the ID vendor question, splitting in 2023 over whether to return to the incumbent card producer.

Domestic supply exists but is narrow. A Ugandan cybersecurity firm has taken ISO/IEC 27001 certification (January 2026), making the standard attainable by a local provider rather than only by foreign firms in the market, and the developer base numbers in the thousands (2025). The largest technology business in the country is a mobile operator whose fintech arm now bills more than its data arm (June 2026).

The content industries are losing ground: legitimate pay-TV subscriptions have roughly halved since 2021 (March 2026), and the communications regulator is convening broadcasters, the mobile operators, the Revenue Authority and the registration bureau into a national anti-piracy framework (July 2026). The conditions around all of this have worsened: Uganda's business and labour environment scores fell over the decade to 2023 on the Ibrahim Index, on economic diversification and on business and competition regulation alike.

Innovation ecosystem

Government has begun asking Ugandan developers to build the state's own systems. In May 2026 the ICT ministry called on local developers, startups, universities and hubs to submit working prototypes for tax, land, hospital records, employment and digital ID, with the stated aim of cutting dependence on foreign technology providers, and a Government Systems Prototype Showcase and National Innovator Registry now invite locally built systems to be built on top of the MOSIP-based national ID.

Money has not followed at the same pace. Ugandan startups raised around US$19 million in 2024, a recovery from the sharp fall of the year before, and the country sat 121st on WIPO's Global Innovation Index in 2024 and 95th on StartupBlink's ecosystem ranking the same year, where activity is flagged as over-concentrated in Kampala. The best-known home-grown names — Tugende, SafeBoda, Numida and Rocket Health — are a short list.

Private risk capital into Ugandan digital companies is thin on the record: only a handful of equity transactions, two of them successive rounds into the same asset-finance company.

The physical ecosystem is going up outside the capital, with ICT innovation hubs operating at Nakawa, Soroti, Kabale and Muni and three more under development at Gulu, Busitema and Fort Portal (August 2026), against a Digital Transformation Roadmap target of functional hubs in every region by 2027. The national hub at Nakawa is run by the ICT institute, Makerere's Innovation and Incubation Centre launched a Fintech Fridays programme with the Afriventia Group in July 2026.

The failure point is at the other end. Innovations out of Uganda's academic and technical institutions struggle to secure intellectual-property protection, manufacturing capacity, investment and the industry partnerships needed for production at scale, and MTN Uganda holds that the binding constraint is not talent but the inability to move solutions past pilot stage (June 2026). The response so far has been fiscal and administrative: a proposed three-year income-tax exemption for qualifying startups, and an instruction on 31 July 2026 giving the ICT institute two weeks to compile a list of innovations ready for commercialisation.

Capacity

Literacy

Uganda's schooling has been going backwards on the measure everything digital is built on top of: its education score on the Ibrahim Index fell 4.6 points over the decade to 43.9 out of 100 (2023), 38th of 54 African states, with completion the weakest part of it at 17.2, down 11.1 points.

A population that has not finished school is then asked to use services on a device most of it does not have — 26% of adults owned an internet-enabled mobile phone (2021), which Afrobarometer traced straight through to whether e-learning was possible at all. On the UN's own reading the binding weakness is the telecommunications infrastructure rather than the human capital behind it, and the education system's own records bear that out from the bottom up: head teachers in rural primary schools still complete annual census forms by hand, to be keyed into the national system later.

Understanding of the rules meant to protect people inside these systems is thinner still, with only a small minority of Ugandans grasping data-protection principles (2025). The official answer has been publicity — NITA-U and the data protection office ran a six-month awareness campaign from December 2025 — but the more instructive work has been done house to house: ADIJUST took data-protection outreach into Kampala's Katanga settlement (August 2026) with the Personal Data Protection Office and the University of Warwick, using local-language discussion, storytelling and a community skit to reach boda boda riders, Village Health Teams, health workers and youth and women leaders.

Ahead of that floor being repaired, the state is already writing for the next layer: UICT is developing an inclusive AI curriculum (November 2025) built on localised, culturally relevant content and disability-inclusive personalised learning, alongside Belgian-funded work on the digital skills and digital rights of women and girls.

Training and skills

Uganda trains at volume and names a destination rarely. The national ICT institute puts its own 2025/26 figure at tens of thousands of people trained in digital and emerging technologies, while the same institute has been unable to absorb the funds allocated to it since the finance ministry took on part of a wage bill it had been meeting out of its own revenue.

Where the destination is stated, it is usually a foreign funder who states it. KOICA is funding a US$12.2 million project at Makerere University from 2025 to 2030 to build open, distance and e-learning capability, down to e-content for 2,560 courses across ten colleges. Two ICT training centres in Mbale have put several hundred young women through training, with intake aimed at the poorest communities rather than the middle class, and a further hub there has been agreed with a UK civil-society body. The Mastercard Foundation's Young Africa Works, a US$200 million ten-year commitment announced in 2020 and running to 2030, carries the digital economy as one enabling sector among agriculture, tourism and construction. Newer arrangements are lighter: the ICT ministry's April 2026 memorandum with the UN Health Industry Foundation and the Prince Kimbugwe Foundation covers AI labs, youth skills training and exchanges with China on smart agriculture, and Makerere's Innovation and Incubation Center has added a regular fintech series with a private partner (July 2026).

Inside government, a digital skills strategy and a running training programme for public servants are in place, free to participants, and the people who build and run the state's systems are counted in ICT Infrastructure rather than here. The clearest unmet demand is narrower than any of the youth programmes address: cybersecurity skills are short where the financial sector needs them. The supply side is not empty — established tertiary institutions offer a range of ICT and computer science programmes — but little of the training on offer is matched to it.

Research institutions

Research on Uganda's most-used digital system runs into a wall at the data: mobile-money operators declined to give researchers real transaction data, leaving the work to proceed on a synthetic set (April 2026).

The compute, at least, is now domestic — a national AI research cloud launched at Makerere with the research and education network in March 2026 hosts model training in the country rather than abroad. What is produced there struggles to leave the building: innovations from academic and technical institutions fail to secure intellectual-property protection, manufacturing capacity, investment and the industry partnerships large-scale production needs, which is consistent with Uganda's bottom-quartile standing on the global innovation index (2024).

Inclusion

Access to services

The High Court, dismissing the challenge to mandatory ID use in June 2025, held that the 32 affidavits filed against the regime, most from named residents of seven districts, "appear to me to be few and isolated cases that could be handled through proper follow up, guidance and assistance rather than as constituting evidence of a failed national ID system".

The friction is documentary. A first-time adult applicant must present an introduction letter signed by the LC1 chairperson and stamped by the Internal Security Officers, giving their name, date of birth, tribe, clan and nationality and the same for both parents, while an under-18 must produce a photocopy of a parent's national ID — so a child's registration runs through a parent's card. At the launch of mass registration in May 2025 the same letter was used to screen out non-citizens, a misidentification risk in Adjumani, which hosts approximately 244,374 refugees and has close cultural and language ties with South Sudan.

The counter does not always behave as published. Residents and local-council leaders of Ruhinda sub county in Rukungiri told a meeting convened by the Resident District Commissioner's office in July 2026 that the NIRA officer there was charging from UGX 2,000 upwards for free services and distributing national IDs from his own residence, and the deputy RDC said such complaints were numerous. Millions of new cards sit uncollected.

The Minister of State for Disability Affairs reported complaints in December 2025 from persons with disabilities of barriers to loans, banking and essential financial services; neither MTN nor Airtel publishes accessibility provisions such as screen-reader support or accessible USSD protocols, and Uganda has no standalone digital inclusion policy. The national financial inclusion strategy for 2023 to 2028 adds refugees and persons with disabilities to its priority groups; refugees themselves remain outside the national identification register.

Price is the lesser obstacle, the mobile data basket sitting in the moderate affordability band (2024). The Ibrahim Index score for Inclusion and Equality stood at 39.0 out of 100 in 2023, down 6.6 points over the decade, with Equal Access to Public Services at 40.6.

Digital divides

The sharpest measured divide is gender, and it is the one that has moved backwards while the rest improved. Uganda's Access to Public Services for Women score was 29.7 out of 100 in 2023, 39th of 54 African states and down 1.3 points over the decade — the weakest of the six measures in a Women's Equality sub-category that otherwise rose 8.9 points to 67.5. GSMA classed the country's mobile gender gap as moderate in 2021. Belgium's Enabel ran Digital for Girls and Women in Uganda on a EUR 2,250,000 budget from 2021 to 2025, working on the digital skills and digital rights of women and girls.

Age and manual work cut across that line. Large numbers of Ugandans could not have usable fingerprints captured at registration, disproportionately elderly people and manual labourers, and that failure is the stated reason for adding iris capture to the registration kits (March 2026). At the other end of the age range, children are far more thinly represented in the identity register than in the population, which is where most of the registration gap sits.

Geographically the divide is Kampala against everywhere else. StartupBlink flagged startup activity as over-concentrated in the capital in 2024, the regulator's own 2025 reporting describes connectivity concentrated in urban centres against limited rural access, and administrative data for 2020 to 2024 shows rural-urban disparities in the timeliness of birth registration that have not closed. Underneath all of it, only a small minority of Ugandans use the internet at all.

The response to it is mostly talk: Airtel Uganda's chief executive and the newly appointed ICT minister, Justine Kasule Lumumba, put smartphone access at the centre of the digital inclusion agenda in July 2026, and between them announced no device-financing scheme, subsidy, target, timeline or investment figure.

Of the seven ICT innovation hubs the ministry named in August 2026, all but one are upcountry rather than in Kampala.

Data

National statistics

Uganda's capacity to count improved faster over the decade to 2023 than most of the continent's: its Capacity of the Statistical System score in the 2024 Ibrahim Index of African Governance rose 10.2 points to 61.3 out of 100, twelfth of 54 African states. The gain is uneven underneath. On the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators for 2023 the system scores highest on data use, above 89 per cent, and lowest on data sources, in the 20 to 49 per cent band, with data products and data infrastructure between 70 and 89 per cent and data services between 50 and 69.

The survey and census programme is the strong half. Uganda had run a population census and a business census within the previous ten years and an agricultural census within twenty, and had fielded three or more household, health and labour surveys in ten years and one agricultural survey — but no business survey at all in that period (2023).

The weakness sits where the state has to count itself rather than go out and ask. Registration of births and deaths reaches only a small fraction of the events that occur (2024), and a NIRA-led technical working group was still drafting data-sharing agreements between the Bureau of Statistics and the institutions that generate civil registration data in April 2026. The identity register's incomplete coverage and a tax roll whose registrations run well ahead of those who file leave the administrative base thinner than the survey base — and the denominators themselves are contested territory, with the telecoms regulator's own reporting separating unique mobile subscribers from registered subscriptions (2023) to figures far apart.

Statistical production is not confined to the Bureau. NITA-U publishes an annual statistical abstract with a multi-year run on the national data sharing and integration platform (2023), and the central bank publishes payment system performance statistics at least annually (2025).

Open data

What Uganda publishes well is mostly money. In Open Data Watch's 2024 Open Data Inventory balance of payments, government finance, international trade, and money and banking each score 7.5 out of 10, ahead of prices at 6.5 and labour at 4.5, while its social and environmental categories cluster between 3.5 and 5.5, education facilities weakest at 3.5. The machinery matches: the open data portal carries a comprehensive catalogue updated weekly or daily, but the publication process is mostly manual (2025), so the refresh rate depends on staff rather than a pipeline. The Ministry of ICT does run a live public dashboard reporting entities onboarded to the UgHub data exchange alongside other national ICT indicators (2023).

Across the GovTech Maturity Index, the documentation behind nineteen of Uganda's answers — the cloud platform, interoperability, financial management, treasury, tax, customs, HR, payroll, procurement, debt, data governance, data protection, right to information, digital skills, innovation and startup support — exists but is held internally and unpublished (2025).

The right to ask for the rest is old and thinly exercised. The Access to Information Act 2005 establishes the statutory right to request records held by the state, and the GovTech index treats the law as effective rather than merely enacted (2025), but Uganda's Disclosure of Public Records stood at 40.8 out of 100 in 2023, seventeenth of 54 and up 1.7 points over the decade, and Accessibility of Public Records at 31.0, twenty-fifth of 54 and up 9.2 — both improving, both low.

Procurement is the exception that shows what is possible. The Public Procurement and Disposal of Public Assets Authority's Government Procurement Portal publishes machine-readable procurement data and is described as one of the strongest transparency tools in the region, and an upgrade to an open contracting standard for infrastructure was announced in November 2025. The limits are set elsewhere: the appeals tribunal has held that an evaluation report in a live procurement is confidential, and the identity register's data exchange with the Electoral Commission runs without a codified, publicly available governance framework (2026).

Use of satellite data

No national Earth observation or geospatial data programme had been established in Uganda as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Starlink entered Uganda on condition the state can see who uses it: the agreement signed with the Uganda Communications Commission at State House in May 2026 requires a national gateway, a physical point of presence, a staffed local office and the registration of every device in the country, with Museveni putting the state's interest as "security, revenue assurance, and accountability... who the customers are". In December 2025 the Uganda Revenue Authority barred imports of Starlink equipment without clearance from the UPDF Chief of Defence Forces, and SpaceX itself wrote to the regulator in January 2026 conceding that Ugandan use of the service had been "without our approval... in violation of our terms of service". Airtel Uganda has since begun testing direct-to-cell service under Airtel Africa's SpaceX agreement (May 2026).

The other American footprint is the platforms, and Uganda has taken jurisdiction over them without waiting for a court. The Personal Data Protection Office held that the country's data-protection law reaches any entity monetising Ugandan users, rejecting Google's argument that it binds only Uganda-domiciled controllers, and applied it again on 20 February 2026 against WhatsApp LLC and Meta Platforms, finding deficiencies in transparency, in tying processing purposes to a lawful basis and in showing compliance with its cross-border transfer requirements. Corrective orders followed and no fine, and by July 2026 WhatsApp had issued a Uganda-specific privacy notice and reworked its consent and disclosure terms.

Physical American hosting amounts to one Azure Stack, launched by Liquid Intelligent Technologies in August 2024 to offer local Azure services under Ugandan data rules. American money is a plan rather than a flow: a five-year United States funding line for health data systems, set out under an America First Global Health Strategy memorandum, falls year on year to 2030, on terms that put ownership of data generated by US-funded programmes with the Government of Uganda and have Uganda approve its national health information architecture before anything is financed.

Across every external digital commitment on Uganda's record, the U.S. Department of State ranks fourth as a financier, behind the World Bank, the Mastercard Foundation and China Eximbank.

China activities

Every phase of Uganda's national transmission backbone but one has been built on Chinese concessional lending: China Eximbank financed Phases I to III between 2006 and 2013 and is financing Phase V, leaving Phase IV (2018), at US$75.8 million, as the sole World Bank exception. The pattern repeats itself. The 2015 Phase 3 loan financed a turnkey contract with Huawei Technologies, and Phase V runs through NITA-U with CITCC as contractor under a commercial contract signed in April 2022. What the lending buys is a repayment obligation and a contractor chain rather than the network itself, which stays with NITA-U.

Chinese state finance accounts for three of the twenty external digital commitments on record (August 2026) and about US$198 million: two China Eximbank concessional loans for the backbone and a Ministry of Commerce grant for customs modernisation.

That grant agreement, signed in June 2017, covered non-intrusive scanners, customs risk-management and supervision systems and border infrastructure for the Uganda Revenue Authority. Chinese vendors have since moved past state contracts into the commercial core: Centenary Bank signed an AI and cloud digital-banking partnership with Huawei in May 2026, the Ministry of ICT signed a memorandum in April 2026 with the UN Health

Industry Foundation and the Prince Kimbugwe Foundation covering AI labs, youth skills training and exchange programmes with China on smart agriculture, and a Vodacom Tanzania tie-up with Thunes now routes M-Pesa payments to Ugandan merchants through MTN MoMo and to Chinese merchants through Alipay (May 2026).

EU activities

Uganda's national identity cards are printed by a company just under half owned by German security printers: the Uganda Security Printing Company, formed in November 2018, is 51% held by government through the Uganda Printing and Publishing Corporation and 49% by a consortium of Veridos GmbH and Giesecke+Devrient GmbH, supervised by the Office of the President and the Ministry of Finance. The arrangement behind it is long: Veridos announced in October 2018 a 15-year partnership covering all production of Uganda's security documents, under which the printing factory for ePassports and polycarbonate ID cards was established with the state printer along with Veridos' IMAGO identity-management platform.

The rules by which government systems talk to each other are European in design and Estonian in authorship. NITA-U's e-Government Interoperability Framework binds every ministry, department, agency and local government as a mandatory technical standard, is modelled on the European Interoperability Framework and is now at version 2; it and the Government Enterprise Architecture were built with Estonia's e-Governance Academy and dated 6 May 2021, and reached their five-year mark with a renewal launched at a multi-agency workshop in Kampala in February 2026, completed on 27 May 2026.

European money is in towers and in training. The European Investment Bank has lent US$16 million to TowerCo of Africa Uganda for 506 signed mobile sites, at least half of them in rural areas with no mobile service, powered primarily by renewable energy and carrying 4G, 5G and mobile money (2023), and Belgium's Enabel ran Digital for Girls and Women on a EUR 2,250,000 budget from 2021 to 2025, working on the digital skills and digital rights of women and girls.

Gulf/UAE activities

Uganda's national identity system is not merely supplied from the Gulf but run from it: the new system is operated for NIRA by the UAE-based service provider Tahaluf, with five MOSIP-based modules and further components from Tech5, Technoforte, Entrust and Hyf (February 2026). The contract was signed on 8 July 2024 and kicked off on 17 July, five weeks after the date on which mass enrolment was originally to have begun. Tahaluf had supplied all 5,665 biometric registration kits for the enrolment by January 2025, alongside two high-speed machines NIRA acquired capable of producing about 100,000 laser-engraved cards a day.

India activities

Airtel's African data centre venture, Nxtra Africa, names Kampala among the edge sites in its expansion plans (December 2024). No Indian-built facility, financing commitment or system operation in Uganda's digital sector had been established as at August 2026.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-08-31**
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/UGA/UGA-status.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/UGA/UGA-status-2026-08-31.pdf
LICENCE	CC BY 4.0

Figures are dated because most are time-varying: a figure carries the date it was true, not the date you are reading it. Where the base holds no reliable statement, the document says **Not held** rather than leaving a silence — those are counted, and listed at the end.

This is a dated edition and is not revised after publication. If a figure here has moved, the current edition will say so.